

PROLOGUE: THE SILENCE

****TIMELINE: EARTH-10005 (THE FUNERAL)****

The worst part wasn't the death. The worst part was the quiet that came after.

The forest was still. The kind of stillness that feels heavy, like a wool blanket soaked in ice water. The Reavers were gone. The children were gone. There was just the wind, moving through the North Dakota pine like a sigh from a god who had given up.

Laura stood over the pile of rocks.

She didn't cry. She was a weapon, just like him. Weapons don't cry; they rust. But inside, something was snapping. A tension wire that had held her world together was suddenly cut.

He's gone, the wind whispered.

It wasn't just a man who had died. It was a gravitational constant. James Howlett. Logan. The Wolverine. He was the thing that the universe anchored itself to—a dense, angry point of mass that kept reality from drifting into the dark.

Without him, the air felt thinner. The colors of the trees looked grey, desaturated. The sunlight that filtered through the canopy seemed weak, as if the sun itself was running out of budget.

A squirrel skittered across a branch. It stopped, sensing the predator in the clearing. It chittered once, then froze.

Even nature knew. The King was dead.

Laura reached out and touched the rough stone of the grave marker. It was cold. It gritty. The X was crude, made of two sticks lashed together with twine. It was a pathetic monument for a man who had saved the world more times than he had smiled.

"Daddy," she whispered.

It was the first time she had said it to a stone. It wouldn't be the last.

Far away, deep in the bedrock of reality, a thread began to fray. A tiny, microscopic unraveling. The timeline shivered. It was a subtle vibration, felt only by those who watched the monitors in a place outside of time.

The Anchor was gone. The ship was adrift.

And somewhere, in a different timeline, a man in a red suit woke up screaming.

CHAPTER 1: NORTH DAKOTA

****TIMELINE: EARTH-10005 (PRESENT DAY)****

The shovel hit something solid.

Thwack.

That's the thing about closure: you always imagine it's soft. You imagine a gentle closing of a book, a fading sunset, a soft piano chord. But real closure? Real closure is hard. It resists. It fights back. It feels like hitting a rock with a piece of cheap gardening equipment at three in the morning.

I stopped digging. My breath plumed in the freezing air, little white ghosts escaping my lungs.

It's cold. Not 'put on a sweater' cold. 'Nipples could cut glass' cold. My suit is thermal, but my soul is exposed.

I leaned on the shovel handle. My back screamed—a sharp, hot line of pain running from my lumbar to my neck. My healing factor was already fixing the micro-tears in the muscle, knitting them back together with a sensation that felt like ants crawling under my skin. It was an itch I couldn't scratch, a biological hum of repair that reminded me I was broken.

Some people get religion. I got acquired. I got a second chance. And I wasted it.

"Come on, Wolvie," I whispered to the dirt. "Don't be shy."

The grave of the Wolverine.

I looked around. The clearing was exactly like it was in the movie. The rocks. The cross (now fallen over, rotting in the damp earth). The eerie sense of sanctity that I was currently violating with a shovel I bought at Home Depot for \$19.99 (plus tax, because even vigilantes pay sales tax).

I am not a grave robber. I am a grave... borrower. A grave enthusiast. A necro-tourist.

I spat on my gloved hands and swung again.

Thwack-crunch.

The sound was wet. The permafrost was melting under my assault. Mud splattered my mask. It smelled of rot and pine needles and the damp, earthy scent of copyright infringement. It tasted like copper and old snow.

Why am I doing this?

Because I have to. Because Vanessa. Because the guy in the suit said my world is dying. And because, let's be honest, I'm the only one with the balls to do it.

The shovel blade scraped metal.

Clang.

The sound vibrated up my arms, rattling my teeth. It was a sound of finality. Of absolute, undeniable reality.

"Jackpot."

I fell to my knees. I started clawing at the dirt with my hands. The soil was freezing, biting through my gloves. I didn't care. I dug like a dog who smelled a bone. A very expensive, Adamantium-coated bone.

"Okay, peanut. Time to wake up. We got work to do."

I cleared the dirt from the lid. It wasn't a coffin. It was a box. A metal box. Scratched. Dented. It looked like it had been chewed on by time itself.

He's in there. He has to be. He's Wolverine. He doesn't die. He takes a nap. He regenerates. He's probably just... really stiff. Like waking up after a keg stand in 1998.

I pried the lid open. The hinges shrieked—a sound like a banshee getting a root canal.

I looked inside.

And the world stopped.

No.

It wasn't a sleeping hero. It wasn't a grumpy Canadian ready to pop his claws and call me 'Bub'.

It was bones.

Just bones.

Shiny. Metallic. Indestructible.

The ribs curved like the grill of a '58 Plymouth. The skull stared up at me, hollow sockets filled with dirt. It seemed to be grinning. Mocking me. A permanent rictus of death.

He's dead. He's actually dead.

I sat back on my heels. The cold seeped into my ass.

"You died?" I asked the skull. My voice cracked. "You actually died? In *Logan*? I thought that was just... artistic license! Oscar bait! You're Wolverine! You regenerate! You don't just... *decompose*."

I poked the skull. It didn't move. It didn't grow skin. It just sat there, being the most expensive paperweight in existence.

Panic. This is panic. It tastes like copper and failure.

"Freeze!"

The voice came from above. Amplified. Mechanical.

I looked up.

TVA Minutemen. A dozen of them. Ringing the clearing. Their prune-sticks glowing with that hateful orange light. They looked like stormtroopers designed by a focus group that hated fun.

"Wade Wilson," the lead agent said. "Step away from the deceased Variant."

I looked at them. I looked at the box of bones.

This is the part where I surrender. This is the part where I give up.

Or...

This is the part where I use a dead man's leg to beat a fascism allegory to death.

"You guys," I said, standing up. "You picked a really bad time. I'm grieving here. This is my emotional support skeleton."

"Prune him," the agent ordered.

I reached down. I grabbed the Adamantium femur. It was heavy. Dense. Balanced. It felt like holding a piece of history.

Music. I need music. Something to drown out the sound of me losing my mind.

"Hit it," I whispered.

BYE BYE BYE START

I launched myself.

The first hit was messy. The femur connected with a helmet. *CRACK.*

Mechanics: The bone didn't give. The helmet did. The force traveled up my arm, a shockwave of kinetic joy.

Consequence: The agent's head snapped back. He dropped like a sack of wet cement. No twitching. Just gravity taking over.

Aftertaste: My arm vibrated. It felt good. It felt... resonant.

I spun. I was dancing. I was a marionette cut loose.

"I! Want! To! Be! With! You!" I sang, synchronizing the blows.

Another agent lunged. I grabbed the skull. I jammed it onto his head. *THUNK.* He flailed, blinded by the face of death. I punched the skull. *CRUNCH.*

One disgusting detail: The agent screamed inside the skull. The sound was muffled, wet, echoing inside the metal cavity. It sounded like someone shouting into a soup can filled with meat.

It was horrifying. It was hilarious.

I am going to hell. But I'm going to have the high score.

Two more agents rushed me. I ducked a glowing baton that sizzled the air where my ear used to be. The smell of ozone filled my nose.

I swung the leg bone low. *CRUNCH.* Kneecaps shattered. The sound was dry, like snapping firewood.

"Don't worry!" I yelled. "I'm a chiropractor! I'm adjusting your attitude!"

I backflipped off a tree stump. I landed on another agent's shoulders. I drove the leg bone down into his collarbone.

SNAP.

He collapsed. I rolled.

The snow around the grave was turning red. A slushy, bloody mess. Steam rose from the fresh kills.

It was a Jackson Pollock painting made of violence and regret.

God, I love this job.

"Is that all of you?" I panted, standing amidst the carnage. I was holding the Adamantium claws in a dual-wield stance. They felt right. They felt heavy.

A portal opened. Orange. Rectangular.

More agents poured out.

Oh, good. The sequel.

I cracked my neck.

"Maximum effort," I muttered. And then, because I couldn't help myself, I added, "And somebody check on the box office tracking. I think we just secured the opening weekend."

CHAPTER 2: THE MASK THAT DOESN'T FIT

****TIMELINE: EARTH-10005 (SIX YEARS LATER)****

The wig itched.

It wasn't a normal itch. It wasn't a mosquito bite or a reaction to cheap shampoo. It was a phantom itch. A sensation that started deep in the scar tissue of my scalp and radiated outward, like a radio signal broadcasting 'You are a fraud' on all frequencies.

I stood in the showroom of Wilson Motors.

The air smelled of floor wax, stale coffee, and the specific, desperate musk of men who work on commission. It was the scent of failure masked by cheap cologne.

"So," the customer said. He was forty-ish. Polo shirt tucked in aggressively tight. The kind of guy who has strong opinions about lawn care and HOA regulations. "Does it have the... you know?"

He made a vague hand gesture that could have meant anything from heated seats to a portal to the dark dimension.

"The sliding doors?" I asked. My voice was smooth. Too smooth. It sounded like someone else's voice. A normal person's voice. A voice that had never screamed in agony while being mutated.

"Yeah. The kids, you know?"

"Sir," I said, patting the hood of the white Kia Carnival. It rang hollow, a tinny sound that echoed in the cavernous dealership. "Let me tell you. These aren't just doors. They are portals to freedom. Hands-free. Because your hands are full. Groceries. Screaming toddlers. The crushing weight of the choices you made in your twenties."

The man laughed. A nervous, dry sound. "Funny guy."

"I try."

I turned away. I walked to the window.

It was raining outside. Grey, miserable rain. The kind that makes you want to listen to The Smiths and stare at a wall. The parking lot was a sea of wet asphalt and unsold inventory.

This is it. This is the dream.

I looked at my reflection in the glass.

Wade Wilson. Toupee. Beige suit. Salesman of the Month plaque on the wall (third place).

I looked... fine. Normal.

But under the suit? Under the cheap polyester blend that chafed my nipples?

My skin was a map of pain. Lumpy. Scarred. A topographic representation of a cancer ward. It looked like an avocado had sex with an older, uglier avocado.

And under the skin?

Empty.

I rubbed my wrist. The bone ached. It was a dull throb, a reminder of the Adamantium handcuffs I wasn't wearing, the katanas I wasn't holding.

Do something, the voice whispered. *Jump through the window. Stab the manager with a stapler. Do a backflip. Anything to prove you're still alive.*

"Wilson!"

Gary. My manager.

I turned. "Gary! My man! Looking... adequate today. Very symmetrical."

"The upsells, Wilson," Gary sighed. He looked tired. He had bags under his eyes that could carry groceries. "You sold the Odyssey, but you didn't push the rust protection. Rust is the enemy."

"Rust is nature, Gary. Entropy. Dust to dust. Rust to rust. Who are we to fight God?"

"Just sell the coating."

"Yes, sir."

I walked back to my desk. I sat down. The chair squeaked. *Eeee-errrk.*

I opened my drawer.

Inside, hidden under a stack of brochures for the 2024 Sorento, was a polaroid.

Vanessa.

She was smiling. It was a real smile, the kind that reached her eyes.

I touched the photo. My finger shook.

I promised her. No more chaos. No more masks. Just Wade.

But Wade is boring. Wade is sad. Wade sells minivans and dreams of violence.

I closed the drawer. I looked around the office.

At the next desk, Peter was on the phone.

"No, ma'am, the floormats are extra," Peter said. He sounded so sincere. "But they are high-quality rubber. They capture... spills."

Peter was happy. He had a locker full of photos of his cats. He had a sugar glider named Muffin. He had a life. He had content.

I had a wig and a lie.

I am the B-story of my own life. I am the comic relief in a tragedy.

I stood up.

"I'm taking a break," I announced.

"You just got here," Gary said.

"Diarrhea," I said. "Explosive. Unpredictable. Like the third act of a superhero movie."

I walked to the bathroom. I locked the door.

I leaned against the sink. I stared at myself in the mirror.

"You're doing great," I told the reflection. "You're nailing it. You're a productive member of society."

The reflection stared back. The eyes were dead.

Liar.

CHAPTER 3: THE QUIET KNIFE

****POV: VANESSA****

Vanessa watched him from the kitchen doorway.

Wade was standing in the living room, practicing his smile.

He didn't know she was there. He was looking in the hallway mirror, adjusting that terrible toupee. He stretched his lips wide, showing teeth. Then he relaxed. Then he tried again.

Smile. Relax. Smile. Relax.

It was like watching a robot learn to be human.

He looked exhausted. Not the physical exhaustion of a fight—she knew that look. That was a good tired. That was the tired of a man who had used his body for something, who had survived something.

This was different. This was the exhaustion of holding a pose for six years. The exhaustion of playing a character that he hated.

"Happy Birthday to me," Wade whispered to the mirror.

His voice broke. Just a little. A tiny crack in the porcelain.

Vanessa felt a sharp pain in her chest. A quiet knife twisting between her ribs.

He's dying, she thought. *Not the cancer. The cancer is gone. But the spark? The chaos? The thing that made him Wade? It's starving.*

She remembered the first time she met him. The bar. The swagger. The way he took up space. He was a disaster, sure. But he was a *beautiful* disaster. He was alive. He burned bright.

Now?

Now he was a car salesman named Wade who wore beige. He was a shadow of himself.

He was doing it for her. She knew that. He was trying to be the man he thought she wanted. The safe man. The man who didn't come home bleeding. The man who could give her a family.

But she missed him.

She missed the mercenary. She missed the edge. She missed the dangerous, unpredictable idiot who made her laugh until she couldn't breathe.

Be careful what you wish for, her mother used to say. *You might get a husband who sells Kias.*

She took a deep breath. She pasted a smile on her face. A real one. Because she did love him. She loved him enough to play along. She loved him enough to pretend she didn't see the cracks.

"Hey, handsome," she called out.

Wade spun around. The mask slammed down instantly. The "Salesman Wade" persona clicked into place like a visor.

"Ness!" He beamed. "You caught me! Just... admiring the merchandise. High resale value on this guy."

He walked over and kissed her.

His lips were warm. But his eyes?

His eyes were screaming. They were panic-stricken, searching hers for approval, for validation.

"Everyone is here," she said. "Blind AI is arguing with the guacamole."

"Classic AI," Wade said. "She hates texture."

He took her hand. His grip was loose. Careful. Like he was afraid he might crush her if he held on too tight. Like he was afraid his own strength would ruin the illusion.

"Let's go party," he said.

"Wade," she said.

He stopped. "Yeah?"

"You okay?"

"Me? Never better. I'm living the dream, baby. The American Dream. Credit debt and lower back pain."

He winked.

It was a lie. A perfect, polished, heartbreaking lie.

I have to let him go, she thought. *If I love him, I have to let him go. I can't keep him in this cage.*

She squeezed his hand.

"Okay," she said. "Let's go."

They walked into the living room.

The party was loud. The smell of cheap tequila and taco meat filled the air.

Blind Al was shouting at Peter.

"It's too chunky, Peter! It's like dipping a chip into a salad!"

"It's rustic, Al!" Peter argued, his mustache quivering with wholesome delight.

Colossus was there, stooping to avoid the ceiling fan. Negasonic was texting. Yukio was glowing.

It was a family. A weird, broken, beautiful family.

But Wade... Wade looked like a ghost haunting his own life.

He grabbed a chimichanga. He laughed at a joke. But his eyes kept drifting to the window. To the rain. To the world outside where he used to be a king.

Knock. Knock. Knock.

The sound cut through the laughter.

Three sharp raps.

Wade froze.

Vanessa saw it. The shift. The tension in his shoulders. The way his hand drifted toward his hip, reaching for a holster that wasn't there.

"I'll get it," Wade said.

He walked to the door.

Vanessa watched him go. And she knew.

This is it. This is the end of the quiet.

CHAPTER 4: THE AVENGER PITCH

TIMELINE: EARTH-616 (THE SACRED TIMELINE)

DATE: MARCH 14, 2018

The elevator ride was quiet.

Not the good kind of quiet. Not the "we just saved the world and are enjoying the silence" quiet. It was the "I am about to ask the coolest kid in school to prom and I am wearing a diaper" kind of quiet.

I checked my watch. It was a Hello Kitty watch. It ticked loudly. *Tick. Tock. Tick. Tock.*

Okay, Wade. Focus. You are Wade Wilson. You are a special forces operative. You have killed dictators with a Zamboni. You can do this.

I adjusted my tie. I wasn't wearing the suit. I was wearing *the* suit. No, not the red one. A business suit. Charcoal. Sharp. I looked like I was about to defend a mob boss in court.

The doors opened.

Stark Tower. Or Avengers Tower. Or whatever they call it this week.

The lobby was sleek. Glass. Chrome. The smell of money and vibranium. It smelled like Elon Musk's cologne, if Elon Musk showered.

I walked to the reception desk.

"Wade Wilson," I said to the receptionist. "Here to see Happy Hogan."

The receptionist looked at me. She didn't blink. "Do you have an appointment?"

"I have a destiny," I said. "And a referral. From Dopinder. He drives a taxi. He knows people."

She sighed. "Floor 42."

I got back in the elevator.

Floor 42. The answer to life, the universe, and everything. That's a good sign. Unless it's a Douglas Adams reference, in which case the planet is about to be demolished to make way for a hyperspace bypass.

The doors opened again.

And there he was.

Happy Hogan. Iron Man's best friend. The guy who drove the car in the movies.

He was sitting behind a desk, looking busy. He was moving papers around. I suspect they were blank.

"Mr. Hogan!" I marched in. "Happy! Can I call you Happy? I feel like we're vibing."

Happy looked up. He looked... annoyed. He looked like a man who had dealt with too many Skrulls before lunch.

"Mr. Wilson," Happy said. "You're late."

"I was saving a cat," I lied. "From a tree. It was a very tall tree. And a very fat cat. It had diabetes. I had to administer insulin."

"Sit down."

I sat. The chair was leather. Expensive leather. It groaned under my weight.

"So," Happy said, looking at my resume. It was written in crayon. "You want to join the Avengers."

"I don't just **want** to join," I said, leaning forward. "I **need** to join. I need to matter, Happy. I've done the solo thing. I've done the X-Men trainee thing—which, by the way, pays in exposure, which doesn't cover rent. I'm ready for the big leagues."

Happy stared at me.

"You're a mercenary," Happy said. "You kill people for money."

"I **un-alive** bad guys for **justice**," I corrected. "And money. But mostly justice. Look, I have skills. I heal. I'm great with swords. I have a very high pain tolerance. And I'm funny. Every team need a funny guy. You have Tony, but he's... sarcastic. I'm **wacky**."

"We don't need wacky," Happy said.

"What do you need?" I asked. Desperation crept into my voice. "I can be serious. Look at this face."

I took off my sunglasses.

Happy winced.

"Okay," I said. "Bad example. But inside? Inside, I am Captain America. I am moral. I am good. I salute the flag. I recycle."

Please, I thought. **Please say yes. I need this. If I'm an Avenger, I matter. If I matter, I'm worthy of Vanessa.**

Happy sighed. He closed the folder.

"No," Happy said.

The word hung in the air.

"No?" I repeated.

"No," Happy said. "You're not Avengers material, Wade. You're... volatile. You're a liability. We save lives. You take them."

"I can change!" I stood up. "I can be non-lethal! I'll use beanbag rounds! I'll use stern language! I'll use interpretive dance!"

"Go home, Wade," Happy said. "Go back to your life. Be a hero to the people who love you. That's

enough."

That's enough.

The words hit me like a physical blow.

It's not enough. Being Wade isn't enough.

I walked out.

I took the elevator down.

I didn't cry. I didn't rage. I just stood there, watching the numbers go down. 42. 41. 40.

Going down, the voice in my head whispered. *All the way to the bottom.*

CHAPTER 5: SNATCH-AND-BAG

TIMELINE: EARTH-10005 (PRESENT DAY)

I opened the door to the apartment.

The party was still going. But the mood had shifted. The cake was gone. The tequila was low.

I had just broken up with Vanessa. Well, technically, we just had a "moment." But it felt like a breakup. It felt like the end of the world.

Knock. Knock. Knock.

"I'll get it," I said.

I opened the door.

TVA agents. Armored. Glowing sticks. Orange vibe.

"Wade Wilson," the lead agent said.

"Not interested," I said, trying to close the door.

He blocked it with a baton.

"This isn't a solicitation," he said. "You are coming with us."

They grabbed me.

"Hey!" I yelled. "Watch the suit! It's a rental!" (It wasn't).

They dragged me into the hallway.

They ripped my clothes off.

"Whoa! Buy a guy a drink first! At least take me to dinner! I like Italian!"

They put me in a TVA prisoner jumper. It smelled of starch and oppression.

Then they shoved me through a portal.

Side Story A: The Junior Agent

POV: AGENT MILLER

Miller stood by the door, watching the prisoner.

The prisoner—Subject 89-7—was currently arguing with the wall.

"The lighting in here is terrible," the prisoner said to the empty air. "It's very 'Soviet chic'. Can we get a ring light?"

Miller didn't answer. He had been warned.

Briefing Officer: "Do not engage. He's a Class-4 Meta-Narrator. He creates false realities through dialogue. He will make you doubt your own existence."

Miller adjusted his grip on his baton. He was new. This was his first week. He just wanted to do a good job. He wanted to protect the Timeline. He had a family back in Sector 4. A wife. Two kids.

"Hey," the prisoner said. He turned to look at Miller.

The prisoner's face was... difficult to look at. Scarred. Melted. But his eyes were blue and piercing. They seemed to see right through Miller's helmet.

"You're new, aren't you?" the prisoner asked.

Miller stared straight ahead.

"I can tell," the prisoner said. "Your uniform is too clean. And you're holding that baton like it's a microphone. You nervous, kid?"

Miller didn't blink.

"It's okay to be nervous," the prisoner whispered. "You're just an extra. A background character. You have no lines. You're just here to get hit."

Miller felt a chill.

"Don't worry," the prisoner smiled. "I'll make it quick. I'll make it memorable. You'll be the guy who got knocked out by Deadpool. That's a legacy, Miller. That's fame."

Miller swallowed. *How does he know my name? I'm not wearing a nametag.*

"I read the script," the prisoner whispered.

Miller took a step back.

Suddenly, the prisoner moved.

He headbutted the lead agent. He grabbed a Tempad.

Miller raised his baton.

"Action!" the prisoner yelled.

CHAPTER 6: THE SACRED TIMELINE

POV: MR. PARADOX

Paradox adjusted his cufflink.

He watched the monitor. Wilson was in the hallway, dismantling his security team with a level of chaotic efficiency that was frankly insulting.

Disgusting, Paradox thought. *He fights like a child throwing a tantrum. No elegance. No precision. Just noise.*

"Sir," his assistant, B-15 (no, not that one, a different one, let's call him Kevin), spoke up. "Should we deploy the heavy containment?"

"No," Paradox said. "Let him come."

"But sir... he's violent."

"He's desperate," Paradox corrected. "Violence is just his language. I speak fluent desperation."

Side Story C: The Efficiency of Mercy

Paradox turned away from the screen. He looked at the Time Ripper.

It hummed in the center of the room. A beautiful machine. Elegant. Final.

People called him a monster. They called him a bureaucrat. But they didn't understand.

The Timeline was sick. It was overgrown. Billions of branches, all withering, all suffering. He had seen timelines where humanity was enslaved by sentient fungi. Timelines where the sun exploded in 1999. Timelines where *Cats* won Best Picture.

He remembered the first time he pruned a timeline. It was a mercy killing. A universe where the Avengers lost in 2012. Earth was a slave colony. Suffering was absolute.

He erased it.

And suddenly... silence. Peace. No more pain.

Mercy is inefficient, he told himself. *Compassion is slow. The Time Ripper is fast. It is clean. It is the ultimate kindness.*

He was saving them. He was saving them from the slow, agonizing death of an Anchor-less existence.

"Mr. Wilson is here," Kevin announced.

The door flew open.

Wade Wilson stood there. He was wearing the suit. The red one. It was filthy.

"Knock knock!" Wilson yelled.

Paradox smiled. He put on his 'Helpful Administrator' face.

"Mr. Wilson," Paradox said. "So glad you could join us. Please. Ignore the blood on the carpet. It's vintage."

"You want to save my world?" Wilson asked. He was panting. "Prove it."

"I don't want to save your world, Wade," Paradox said softly. "I want to save *you*."

He walked around the desk.

"Your world is a cancer," Paradox said. "It is stage four. I am the surgeon. And you... you are the healthy cell I am transplanting."

Wilson stared at him.

"You're not a surgeon," Wilson said. "You're a butcher."

"Semantics," Paradox waved a hand. "Now. Let's talk about the Avengers."